EDITION 16

Why cross-border payments are slow. from someone who has cleared them.

SWIFT moves enormous value every year. The delays people blame on it usually live somewhere else entirely.

A **7**-part breakdown

SWIPE >>>>

0101 / 07

The thing people get wrong about SWIFT.

SWIFT is mostly messaging, not movement. When a cross-border payment crawls, the hold-up is usually the banks in the chain, not the message.

Correspondent banking, briefly.

Your bank may not have a relationship with the destination bank, so the payment hops through intermediaries. Each hop adds a check, a fee, and a delay.

0303 / 07

Where the time actually goes.

Compliance screening, cut-off windows, time zones, and funding at each hop. I have chased these exceptions. The message arrives fast. The money waits.

0404 / 07

What is genuinely changing.

Domestic real-time rails are starting to link across borders, like Pix and UPI. Settle locally on both ends and you skip several hops.

0505 / 07

Why incumbents are not dead.

Cross-border still needs compliance, finality and dispute handling. Linked rails solve speed, not the hard parts. Both have to be built.

0606 / 07

The operator's take.

The friction was never the messaging standard. It was the chain of trust underneath it. Shorten the chain and the speed follows.

0707 / 07

Save this.

Cross-border is slow because of the hops, not the message. Fix the hops.

THE TAKEAWAY

Does SWIFT survive?

Comment your verdict — adaptation or fax machine. Repost to share it, and follow for daily agentic payments breakdowns.

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